RESEARCH SYNTHESIS · 14 INTERVIEWS · SEPT 2026

Why busy parents abandon meal planning by Wednesday

THEME 1

Plans break on contact with real life

"Monday's plan is fiction by Tuesday — someone has football."

9 of 14 replan midweek

Leftovers never in the plan

THEME 2

The shopping list is the real product

"I don't care about recipes. I care that the list is right."

Lists shared in WhatsApp

Aisle order matters

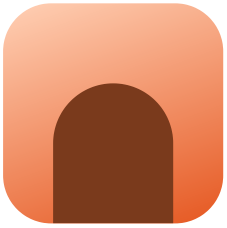
THEME 3

Kids veto more than budgets do

"If my son won't eat it, it doesn't matter how cheap it is."

Picky-eater swaps wanted

Kids like choosing 1 meal



PRIMARY PERSONA

Jess, 38 — "the default planner"

Works 4 days a week, two kids (7 and 11). Plans on Sunday night on her phone, shops online Monday. Wants dinner sorted in 10 minutes a week and fewer "what's for tea?" texts.

KEY INSIGHTS

01 **Design for replanning, not planning.** A one-tap "swap Wednesday" beats a perfect Sunday plan.

02 **Make the list shareable and sorted.** Export to WhatsApp and the household's usual store.

03 **Give kids a vote.** A weekly "kid's pick" increased stated plan completion in concept tests.